

LAMARR, HEDY (1914–2000)

Best known as a Hollywood actress, the Austrian-American Lamarr is now recognized as an important inventor. In 1941, with her business partner George Antheil, she received the patent for a wireless communication system (a forerunner of Wi-Fi and Bluetooth technology) to be used by the military. “Inventions are easy for me to do,” she later claimed. “I suppose I just came from a different planet.”

LEIZU OR XI LING SHI (2ND MILLENNIUM BCE)

The Chinese teacher Confucius told the story of how the ancient empress Leizu became the first person to discover silk. Around 2640 BCE, the young wife of Emperor Huangdi was sitting under a mulberry tree when the cocoon of a silkworm fell in her teacup and she saw how it was formed of tiny threads. This revelation inspired her to rear silkworms and experiment with the fibers to create silk fabric using a loom—a process that became known as sericulture.

MANGANO, JOY (1956–)

American inventor Mangano has patents for hundreds of everyday products, from wheeled luggage and jewelry boxes to rubber platform shoes and reading glasses. In 1990, she invented the Miracle Mop, a self-wringing plastic floor mop with a self-rinsing cotton head. Now a

multimillionaire, she heads her own company, Ingenious Designs Inc. In 2015, her story was made into the film *Joy*, starring Jennifer Lawrence.

MARCONI, GUGLIELMO (1874–1937)

The “father of radio” was a young Italian scientist called Guglielmo Marconi. He was fascinated by radio waves and, through tireless experimentation, pioneered long-distance radio transmission and radio telegraphy. In 1896, Marconi demonstrated the first wireless transmission between buildings in London, UK. The following year, his equipment could transmit across the English Channel and, by 1901, across the Atlantic Ocean to the US. He shared the Nobel Prize for Physics in 1909.

MASON, STANLEY (1921–2006)

The American businessman and inventor worked on a multitude of consumer items, including microwave cookware, plastic dental floss, baby wipes, sports bras, and surgical masks. The squeezable ketchup bottle and fitted disposable diaper are his most famous creations. The diaper came about when he had his own children: “I held up the cloth diaper, and it was square. I looked at the baby, and it was round. I knew there was an engineering problem.”

IBUKA, MASARU (1908–1997)

The Japanese industrialist started his career in a photochemical laboratory, where he showed early promise as an inventor with his modulated light transmission system—a kind of neon. He founded the company that would become Sony in 1949,



developing the first Japanese tape recorder, a transistor radio, and the Trinitron TV system. The Walkman of 1979 was inspired by Ibuka’s love of listening to opera on long flights and the need for a streamlined, lightweight, portable, personal player.

MATZELIGER, JAN ERNST (1852–1889)

Born to a Dutch father and a slave mother, the Surinamese inventor developed an early interest in machinery at his father’s shipyard. By 1877, employed in a shoe factory in Massachusetts, he began figuring out how to attach a shoe sole to its upper by machine. This job was done by hand and even a skilled worker could complete only 50 pairs a day. Matzeliger’s machine, patented in 1883, raised shoe production to between 150 and 700 pairs a day.

MONTAGU, JOHN (1718–1792)

In 1762, the British statesman and 4th Earl of Sandwich ordered a chef to make him something he could eat with his hands so he could snack without going to the dinner table. The result was the sandwich—meat, for instance, between slices of bread.

OTIS, ELISHA (1811–1861)

The American inventor of the safety device for elevators was a self-taught mechanic who also patented an automatic turner for making wooden bedframes, a steam plow, and a railroad safety brake. The safety device, developed in the 1850s, was simple, employing springs to

